

Chapter 106-1

Liang Wanwan's voice was still trembling, shaky and quivering.

It was also the first time Liang Shi heard her call her "jie."

Ever since Liang Shi had transmigrated into this world, Liang Wanwan's presence had been very low. She had only met Liang Wanwan once. She had a reserved personality—possibly related to her studying painting—and her whole person gave off a melancholic feeling.

The only memory related to Liang Wanwan was that the original host had once stood up for her in high school, which was how she had formed a grudge with Zhou Yi'an.

Even so, this younger sister hadn't been very close to the original host.

Liang Shi often forgot there was still a younger sister in the family.

Liang Wanwan was currently in university, living on campus. Even though her school wasn't far from the villa, she didn't go home very often.

Every weekend, there were lots of club activities and class activities at school. If she didn't want to go home, she could find many excuses.

And she often went out on sketching trips—this was the excuse she used most for not going home.

Liang Shi had never seen her paintings and didn't have a deep impression of her as a person.

Suddenly receiving her call now, Liang Shi was stunned for a few seconds. But upon hearing that she had slapped Liang Xinran, Liang Shi immediately snapped back to attention: "You hit her? Why?"

"She put Chen Mian's sketchbook through the wash." After saying this, Liang Wanwan started sobbing again, only repeating that name: "Chen Mian..."

It sounded like someone very important to Liang Wanwan.

Liang Shi comforted her: "Don't cry first. Where are you now?"

"At Yujiang Bridge," Liang Wanwan said. "I'm looking at the scenery."

Liang Shi: "....."

Yujiang Bridge was the bridge outside their neighborhood. Quite a few people jumped into the river there every year. Hearing that Liang Wanwan was there, Liang Shi couldn't tell if her "looking at the scenery" was real or not.

A few seconds later, Liang Shi said: "Don't do anything impulsive. It's just slapping Liang Xinran once, right? What can she do about it?"

As Liang Shi spoke, she gestured to Xu Qingzhu, signaling her to go get the car first and then come pick her up. But Xu Qingzhu said: "You keep talking on the phone. I'll go get the car."

Before Liang Shi could discuss it further, she had already borrowed an umbrella from a girl and left.

But Liang Wanwan was speaking on the other end, so Liang Shi had to focus on talking to her first.

Liang Wanwan sniffled. The wind in the receiver was much stronger than where Liang Shi was—after all, she was near the river. Even Liang Wanwan's voice sounded ethereal.

"I don't know," Liang Wanwan said. "I don't dare go home."

Liang Shi: "....."

"Have you contacted Dage and Erge¹?" Liang Shi asked.

Liang Wanwan said: "Mom asked me to sound out Dage's intentions before, so Dage stopped answering my calls. Erge... Erge is the same as Dage. His phone is turned off."

Liang Shi: "....."

This move of "pulling the rug out"² was really fast.

But these two had taken their wives and children when they pulled the rug out—how did they forget to bring Liang Wanwan along?

"Don't you usually not go home?" Liang Shi finally remembered. "Why did you go back today?"

"It's Sunday," Liang Wanwan said. "The temperature is dropping this week, so I went home to get clothes. No, she... she put Chen Mian's sketchbook through the wash."

"Is this sketchbook very important?" Liang Shi asked.

Liang Wanwan paused, hiccupping from crying. "Jie, you don't remember Chen Mian?"

Liang Shi: "....."

Who was this again?!

Liang Shi made up an excuse for herself: "I've been a bit tired lately. My memory seems to be declining. I can't recall at the moment."

From Liang Wanwan's end, there was only the sound of wind.

Footnotes:

¹ Dage and Erge (大哥/二哥): "Eldest brother" and "second brother" respectively. In Chinese families, siblings are often addressed by their birth order rather than their names.

² "Pulling the rug out" (釜底抽薪): A Chinese idiom literally meaning "removing the firewood from under the cauldron." It refers to a strategy of removing the root cause of a problem or undermining someone's foundation. In this context, it refers to the brothers cutting ties with the family.

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After a moment, Liang Wanwan said in a low voice: "It's Chen Mian, the one who loves painting."

As soon as this brief introduction came out, a figure emerged in Liang Shi's mind.

The girl wasn't strikingly beautiful. She had a mole under her eye, very long eyelashes, and abnormally pale skin. She rarely got sun exposure, as if she were a nocturnal creature—she always carried an umbrella when going out. She often sat in the art studio for hours at a time, and once she picked up a brush, she wouldn't put it down.

She was a very quiet person.

Especially the melancholic aura about her—it was many times heavier than Liang Wanwan's.

Just by standing there, you would feel she was either an unappreciated talent or someone plagued by misfortune.

The name Chen Mian also suited her perfectly.

Liang Shi initially couldn't dig this person out of her memories, simply because the name wasn't memorable, and the original host hadn't had much interaction with her.

And these were all very distant memories.

This was just someone the original host had met while learning to paint in middle school. They could only be called art studio classmates—they had studied together for two years but barely exchanged a few words.

However, Chen Mian had once approached her on her own initiative back then, saying only two things.

One was: "So you're Liang Shi."

The other was: "Nothing special."

It seemed like a provocation.

For the original host at that time, of course she threw a punch.

But unexpectedly, Chen Mian, who looked so sickly and weak that she had no fighting ability whatsoever, actually caught the original host's fist with her bare hand. Then she curved her lips into a slight sneer and turned to walk away.

This was the only interaction they had during their student days.

But Chen Mian later became famous.

Liang Wanwan really liked her painting style, so she mustered up the courage to ask Liang Shi to get Chen Mian's autograph.

This was one of the rare times Liang Wanwan asked the original host for anything.

After hearing this request, Liang Shi hesitated for a moment and asked: "Can't you just buy one?"

"Jie, you can't buy one," Liang Wanwan said. "Chen Mian almost never gives autographs. She only paints."

The original host, being wealthy and generous: "Then buy her paintings."

"Can't buy those either," Liang Wanwan said. "Her paintings are only displayed at exhibitions. She never allows private collections."

Looking at Liang Wanwan's eager eyes, the original host finally compromised: "I can only try asking for you. I can't guarantee it'll work."

Even with just this promise, Liang Wanwan was very happy.

The original host hadn't contacted Chen Mian for a very long time by then, but she had added all kinds of people to her account. So from her account with nearly a thousand contacts, she found Chen Mian's WeChat.

The WeChat profile picture was a moon—a very dim moon. The composition wasn't particularly remarkable either.

The original host, who was never good at asking others for favors, sat there thinking about her wording for half an hour, figuring out how to bring this up with Chen Mian.

After much deliberation, she just sent a cocky voice message: "Chen Mian, is this you?"

The original host said: "My painting skills are 'nothing special,' but you're so amazing. Can you give me an autograph?"

Chen Mian quickly replied: [Liang Shi?]

The original host responded with an "mm" and also told her: "I can pay you too."

After a long while, Chen Mian said: [Let's meet.]

Then she gave an address and time.

The original host brought Liang Wanwan along. The day they met Chen Mian was still bright and sunny, but Chen Mian had brought a black umbrella. When she closed the umbrella handle, the black contrasted sharply with her almost sickly pale skin—quite eye-catching.

She was still the same as many years ago, unchanged.

Liang Wanwan sat next to the original host, her eyes full of anticipation.

The original host first cleared herself of any misunderstanding: "It's my younger sister who really likes you. I haven't painted for many years."

Chen Mian laughed lightly, her voice cool and detached: "I never said you liked me."

Chen Mian asked her: "Have you been doing well these years?"

It was just like old friends catching up, but the original host had no old times to catch up on with her.

They weren't the kind of relationship where they could exchange pleasantries upon meeting.

They had barely interacted during their student days, so meeting now left the original host puzzled.

But this person had always been an oddball. The original host didn't think too much about it, gave a perfunctory response, and then had Liang Wanwan take out the paper she had prepared, wanting Chen Mian to sign it.

But Chen Mian didn't sign. She still insisted on her viewpoint: "A painter's brush is for painting, not for signing autographs."

So Chen Mian drew over twenty pictures on sticky notes for Liang Wanwan.

They were simple sketches.

There was also one piece that was Chen Mian's earliest work—that moon painting. She said she wanted to give it to Liang Shi.

And she required that Liang Shi not give it away to anyone else.

The original host didn't think much of it at the time. She accepted the painting that she couldn't make heads or tails of and casually agreed to Chen Mian's request.

But after returning home, she directly gave it to Liang Wanwan.

Liang Wanwan didn't even dare accept it, feeling it was her idol's heartfelt work and had been specifically meant for her to keep. But the original host said: "I don't have any art appreciation ability right now. If this thing stays with me, it'll just end up getting burned."

Liang Wanwan treasured that painting at home, while she carried the sketchbook with her at all times.

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Liang Shi struggled to piece this memory back together in her mind, then recalled that very quiet and reserved Chen Mian.

Chen Mian, who had now become a famous painter.

She was still as "strange" as ever.

But Liang Shi didn't dwell on it for long and brought the topic back to Liang Xinran: "Liang Xinran put Chen Mian's sketchbook through the wash?"

"Yes." Liang Wanwan became sad as she talked about this. "I was just changing clothes for a moment, and she threw my jacket into the washing machine. Even though those papers were laminated, they still got completely soaked."

.....

When you thought about it, Liang Wanwan was just unlucky.

Qiu Zimin had called her saying she was sick, and that Dage and Erge were both going to leave home.

Liang Wanwan was worried. After finishing her sketching trip during the day, she returned to the villa that evening.

She habitually carried Chen Mian's sketchbook with her. She usually kept it in her bag, but she hadn't brought her bag today, so she put it in her jacket pocket. She liked to flip through it when she had nothing to do.

Although this sketchbook was something Liang Shi had helped her obtain, Liang Shi didn't know that Liang Wanwan had actually been secretly in love with Chen Mian for many years.

From the time Liang Wanwan went to the art studio to find Liang Shi and bring the brushes she had left at home, she had seen the girl sitting by the window painting.

The girl's skin was an almost sickly pale. Her pupils were very small. She sat before the easel with great concentration. Sunlight fell on her nearly sickly white skin—there was clearly nothing remarkable about it, but in Liang Wanwan's eyes, it made her lose herself.

At that time, Liang Wanwan simply thought she was beautiful and felt a hazy kind of fondness.

She just wanted to get to know that jiejie.

She didn't know what kind of feelings those were, or perhaps those feelings hadn't yet sprouted.

Afterward, she frequently used the same excuse to go to Liang Shi's art studio, frequently seeing Chen Mian.

But Chen Mian never noticed her.

Chen Mian was always painting one particular painting—the back view of a girl wearing a white dress.

Chen Mian was always melancholic, sentimental, yet captivating.

As she grew older, Liang Wanwan finally understood her own feelings. She hid this affection away and didn't dare approach Chen Mian.

Chen Mian was a lonely moon that could only be gazed upon from afar.

Wanting Chen Mian's autograph was also because she wanted to put an end to her absurd secret crush.

She couldn't be the most special person by Chen Mian's side, nor could she be Chen Mian's sweetheart, so she just wanted a special autograph.

That way, she wouldn't have wasted her youth.

So she had gone to Liang Shi.

Liang Wanwan didn't get Chen Mian's autograph, but she got a sketchbook more precious than any autograph. Yet she couldn't feel happy.

For her, an autograph could have put an end to that secret crush.

But the sketchbook had ignited hope within her. She would always pay attention to Chen Mian on various platforms, following her works and activities.

She only had one person in her Weibo special follows—Chen Mian.

That sketchbook was her only hope, containing all the emotions of her adolescence and even now.

Liang Wanwan valued this sketchbook so much that even Ling Dang knew it must never be touched.

So Liang Wanwan hadn't been careful. After returning home, she casually threw her jacket on the sofa and went to see Qiu Zimin.

Qiu Zimin had just returned from the hospital not long ago. She sat on the bed looking sickly, her complexion pale, and she seemed to have aged considerably.

Liang Wanwan sat by the bed comforting her, hearing the same old things—that Liang Shi was too good at manipulating people, that both her brothers were siding with her, that they were causing chaos in the family right now, and that she really shouldn't have picked up Liang Shi in the first place.

The advice to Liang Wanwan was also the same as before: stay away from Liang Shi, don't hang around with that kind of person.

Liang Wanwan was inarticulate, not good at speaking, and had a dull personality. She was used to being invisible at home.

She wasn't as flamboyant as Liang Shi, who received all of Qiu Zimin's favor and could do whatever she wanted.

The things Qiu Zimin said to her most often were: don't compare yourself to your jie, don't learn from her, stay away from her.

Liang Wanwan didn't dare defy Qiu Zimin or go against her wishes, so she usually tried not to talk to Liang Shi. Especially since she didn't often talk to anyone in this family anyway—she was often forgotten even when sharing the same space with everyone.

She had gotten used to it.

But anyone would feel uncomfortable hearing Qiu Zimin say such things, so after starting university, Liang Wanwan didn't come home often.

She would rather be invisible at school than be invisible at home.

Liang Wanwan did know that her brothers and sister were all quite nice.

Her two brothers were much older than her. Although they looked after her too, it wasn't as much as Liang Shi did.

Her middle school wasn't far from Liang Shi's school. Back then, Liang Shi had already started being a troublemaker.

But as her younger sister, Liang Wanwan wasn't as formidable as her. Instead, she was often isolated at school.

Liang Shi had once told her: "Maybe it's you who's isolating the entire world."

Liang Wanwan was what people commonly called someone with strong "dull perception"¹, so Qiu Zimin's words went in one ear and out the other. She just reminded her to rest well.

Because she still had early classes tomorrow, Liang Wanwan went back to her room to pack up and was about to leave. When she went downstairs to put on her jacket, she found she couldn't find it.

She was scared to death. She called several servants, but none of them knew. Then she saw Liang Xinran smiling and asking her: "Are you looking for the one you wore when you came back? I saw it had mud splatters on it, so I took it to wash. I put a new one on the sofa for you."

Liang Wanwan nearly broke down on the spot. She rushed to the washing machine, almost reaching in with her bare hands to grab the clothes.

Liang Xinran pressed pause on the washing machine and asked cautiously: "What's wrong?"

Liang Wanwan couldn't be bothered to respond to her. She pulled her jacket out of the washing machine, only to find that all the sticky notes had been soaked. They had been kept for several years—how could they possibly be of good enough quality to withstand this?

Not being completely ruined was already the best outcome.

But that was Chen Mian's sketchbook.

Liang Wanwan placed it by her pillow every night—it was something she had poured all her hopes into, day and night.

Now it was gone, just like that.

Liang Wanwan looked at her and shouted: "Why did you touch my things?"

The usually silent, wooden, and taciturn Fourth Miss suddenly erupted, startling even the servants.

Liang Xinran stood in front of her, opening and closing her mouth hesitantly, then said: "I... saw your clothes were dirty, so I wanted to help you. It just so happened that last time when I went shopping with... with Mom, I saw some clothes that would suit you. I wanted to see you in pretty clothes."

"Then why didn't you check the pockets before washing?" Liang Wanwan demanded.

Liang Xinran stammered: "I... I forgot."

Her expression was innocent, which only made people more irritated.

Liang Wanwan looked at the sketchbook in her hands, all kinds of emotions piling up in her heart. She gritted her teeth, thinking of Qiu Zimin still lying sick in bed, and was about to swallow her anger.

But then Liang Xinran said: "Is this... thing very important? I'm sorry, Wanwan. Let me get you a new one."

The moment those words fell, Liang Wanwan couldn't help but slap her.

The crisp sound of the slap echoed through the house, stunning all the servants.

This... was this still the same wooden Fourth Miss?

Liang Wanwan said angrily: "You can't afford to replace it!"

After saying that, she ran off.

Footnotes:

¹ "Dull perception" (鈍感力): A Japanese concept (donkanryoku) that refers to the ability to let things roll off one's back, not being overly sensitive to criticism or negative situations. In this context, it means Liang Wanwan doesn't take things to heart easily.

Chapter 106-4

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Liang Wanwan was timid and didn't dare stay behind to face Qiu Zimin's anger.

Even Dage and Erge had moved out. If she were to argue with Liang Xinran in that house, she would definitely be the one wronged.

If it were any other time, she would just let it go. But now Chen Mian's sketchbook had been ruined. She didn't want to hear another word.

After hearing everything Liang Wanwan had to say, Liang Shi sighed helplessly.

The rain outside had let up. Liang Shi sat in the car and told Liang Wanwan to wait for her on the bridge.

She and Xu Qingzhu drove back home.

After hanging up the phone, Liang Shi remarked: "I didn't expect Wanwan would actually get physical."

"Her favorite thing was ruined," Xu Qingzhu said. "It's understandable."

Liang Shi subconsciously asked: "Then what's your favorite thing?"

As she spoke, she conveniently turned on the car stereo. Xu Qingzhu's voice overlapped with the intro music.

Liang Shi didn't hear clearly and asked again: "What did you say?"

Xu Qingzhu changed the "you" from just now to a different answer: "My favorite..."

She paused, then laughed lightly, as if recalling a beautiful memory. Her voice became gentle: "A jiejie from when I was little."